

for the household. In ancient Rome, bay laurel leaves were used as a medicine, a spice, and a decorative garland during the December festival of Saturnalia. Bay laurel was sacred to the gods Apollo and Asclepius, who together oversaw healing and medicine. The herb was thought to be greatly protective and healing. An infusion of the leaves was taken for its warming and tonic effect on the stomach and bladder, and a plaster made from the leaves was used to relieve wasp and bee stings.



Bay laurel
adorned victors in
ancient Greece.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Bay laurel is used mainly to treat upper digestive tract disorders and to ease arthritic aches and pains. It is settling to the stomach and has a tonic effect, stimulating the appetite and the secretion of digestive juices. When used as an ingredient in cooking, bay laurel leaves promote the digestion and absorption of food. The leaves have much the same kind of positive effect as spearmint (*Mentha spicata*) and rosemary (*Rosmarinus officinalis*, p. 128) in assisting the breakdown of heavy food, especially meat. Bay laurel has also been used to promote the onset of menstrual periods. The essential oil is chiefly employed as a friction rub, being well diluted in a carrier oil and massaged into aching muscles and joints. A decoction of the leaves may be added to a bath to ease aching limbs.

Cautions Never take bay laurel essential oil internally. An allergic reaction may result from external use, therefore the oil should only be applied in very dilute (2%) concentrations.

Lawsonia inermis syn. *L. alba* (Lythraceae)

Henna

Description Heavily scented evergreen shrub or tree growing to 20 ft (6 m). Has narrow pointed leaves, clusters of small white or pink flowers, and blue-black berries.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to the Middle East, North Africa, and the Indian subcontinent, henna grows in sunny areas and is widely cultivated for use as a hair restorative and dye. The leaves are picked during the growing season.

Parts Used Leaves, bark.

Constituents Henna contains coumarins, naphthaquinones (including lawsone), flavonoids, sterols, and tannins.

History & Folklore Henna has been used for thousands of years in North Africa and Asia as a red dye and as a scent. Mummies were wrapped in henna-dyed cloth in ancient Egypt. In the Middle East and India, the leaves have traditionally been used to make a pigment for dyeing intricate linear patterns on the fingers, palms, and feet. The leaves have also been used to dye not only human hair but the manes and tails of horses. Before meeting Antony, Cleopatra reputedly soaked the sails of her barge in heady henna flower oil.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Used mainly within Ayurvedic and Unani medicine, henna leaves are commonly taken as a gargle for sore throats, and as an infusion or decoction for diarrhea and dysentery. The leaves are astringent, prevent hemorrhaging, and strongly promote menstrual flow. A decoction of the bark is used to treat liver problems. Applied in the form of a plaster, henna treats fungal infections, acne, and boils.

Leonurus cardiaca (Lamiaceae)

Motherwort

Description Perennial herb growing to 5 ft (1.5 m). Has toothed, palm-shaped leaves and double-lipped pink flowers blossoming in clusters.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to central Asia, motherwort is now naturalized in much of Europe and North America. It grows wild in woodlands, in open areas, and along roadsides. It is also cultivated as a garden plant. Motherwort is harvested when it comes into flower in summer.

Parts Used Aerial parts.

Constituents Motherwort contains alkaloids (including L-stachydrine), an iridoid (leonurine), diterpenes, flavonoids, caffeic acid, and tannins.

History & Folklore As its species name *cardiaca* indicates, motherwort has long been considered a heart remedy. The herbalist Nicholas

Culpeper stated that “there is no better herb to drive away melancholy vapours from the heart, to strengthen it and make the mind cheerful” (1652). The Italian physician and herbalist Pierandrea Matteoli held it “useful for palpitations and a pounding heart, spasms and paralysis... [it] thins thick and viscid humours [and] stimulates urine and menstrual bleeding” (1548).

Medicinal Actions & Uses A remedy for the heart and nerves and often prescribed for palpitations, motherwort strengthens heart function, especially where it is weak. Antispasmodic and sedative, the herb promotes relaxation rather than drowsiness. However, motherwort stimulates the muscles of the uterus, and is particularly suitable for delayed periods, period pain, and premenstrual syndrome (especially if shock or distress is a factor). It should not be used if menstrual bleeding is heavy.



Motherwort has been used to treat palpitations since at least the 16th century.

Related Species Two East Asian species, *L. heterophyllus* (from China) and *L. sibiricus* (from Siberia), are both used therapeutically for the same purposes as motherwort. *L. heterophyllus* appears to lower blood pressure and to induce menstruation.

Cautions Do not take motherwort during pregnancy. It should also be avoided where there is heavy menstrual bleeding.

Self-help Uses Menstrual problems—irregular cycle, p. 315; Panic attacks, p. 302.

Lepidium virginicum (Brassicaceae)

Virginia Peppergrass

Description Annual herb growing to about 2 ft (60 cm). Has slender lance-shaped leaves and small white flowers.

Habitat & Cultivation Virginia peppergrass is native to eastern North America and the Caribbean,